

Going the Mod Way

Quake Rally

Turn *Quake III* into a full-fledged racing sim. This mod supports up to 16 opponents in multiplayer, and while winning the race is one of the goals of the game, you also get points for blowing up your opponents with the various *Quake*



weapons of destruction. The handling is good, and behaves like a real rally racer, with power

slides and skids—all very easy to pull off. While the jumps do seem exaggerated (cars fly through air for what seem like miles), the steering works amazingly well.

The single-player option has 'timer trials' where you race around a track, trying to 'beat the clock', while collecting the various flags to boost your time. Despite the bugs and a weak single player mode, it scores big points for just being *Quake Rally*, a racing simulation for *Quake III*. One can't even begin to imagine the technical hurdles the modders would have encountered while attempting to code something like this. But it just goes to prove that with the *Quake* engine, anything is possible.

Jailbreak

Jailbreak originally started out as a *Quake II* mod by Team Reaction. The concept has been ported to *Quake III* and *Half-Life* as well. A CTF variant, Jailbreak continues the eternal battle between the reds and the blues. Instead of trying to capture a flag or a goal, your team must capture the entire enemy team. When you have fragged an enemy player, he is captured and placed in the jail in your team's base. When all the enemy players have been captured, they are executed and your team scores the capture point.



Jailbreak is a fast moving game where your objectives are constantly changing. Do you mount an attack and try and get the enemy in jail? Do you hold back and defend your release button? Do you stand guard near the jail's escape route to pick off any escapee? These strategies help shift the momentum back and forth in the game. The mounting tension and decision-making that Jailbreak brings makes for some adrenaline-pumping moments.



Online Games

These games aren't meant to suck up days and weeks of your life, but rather provide 30 minutes of fun before bedtime (or during your lunch break). The Internet offers an incredible variety of gaming experiences that would appeal to everyone, from sweet old grandmas to military strategists. When you're ready to set sail on your online gaming adventure, the sites listed here are worth a visit.

Microsoft Gaming Zone

<http://zone.msn.com>

A multifaceted resource, Microsoft's Gaming Zone includes dozens of attractive casual games, plus an extensive network of head-to-head, opponent-matching services for serious players.

Shockwave

www.shockwave.com

The Macromedia Shockwave browser plug-in lets you play graphically rich online games with minimal download times. There's a great collection of faithfully recreated arcade classics (*Joust*, *Defender*, *Sinistar*, and more), sports and adventure titles, along with a wide variety of puzzle games.

The Station

www.station.sony.com

There are plenty of free choices here—from dating games to multiplayer incarnations of *Wheel of Fortune* that play just like the real thing. Sony's Station has the most amusing line up of games that you can play against people from over the world in real time.

Yahoo! Games

<http://games.yahoo.com>

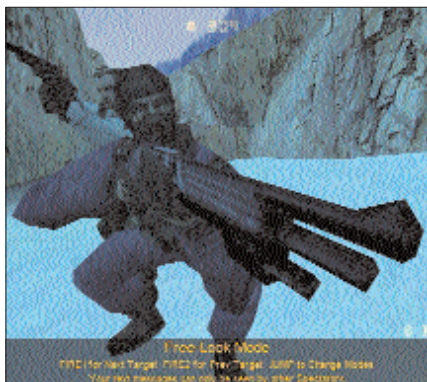
You'll always find plenty of players here ready for a quick board, card or tile game. And as the games are Java-based, no lengthy downloads are required.

involved, be it changes to physics, gameplay or game rules. User modifications are vastly prevalent in the online gaming community.

Mods are no longer simple hacks; they can rival commercial games in refinement and gameplay. Today, they are far

and purpose of the game. Mod makers change everything about the game, from adding new player models, new textures and maps to new game modes. Game concepts such as 'Team Fortress' and 'Capture the Flag' have been ported to almost every popular 3D shooter.

First-person shooters have indirectly benefited from the mod community. With revamped and refined modes of gameplay, *Half-Life* got an extra lease of life. Even after four years, it continues to sell because of gamers who want to play *Counter-Strike* (a popular team-based modification). Game developers support the mod community because they realise that the latter can come up with great ideas and can make the best use of a game's potential. User-made expansions are being encouraged by many game development outfits through the inclusion of track editors, level editors and construction kits with the game. Editing tools do their part to encourage users to fiddle around with the game, while showering gamers with new and unique mods.



Counter-Strike: The most successful mod ever

better than commercial add-ons in gameplay and complexity. Total Conversions are modifications that are so significant that they change the entire appearance

Mods are found in other game genres as well. *Command and Conquer* features several mods that alter its gameplay and add new units and buildings. *Age of Empires* has a mod pack studio, which serves as a full-featured editor that lets you create mod packs of your own.

So go ahead and explore the Net. There are more than enough goodies to provide you a lifetime of free gaming.

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